

Session 21: Jacob Builds an Ark

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov encounters the divine both as he leaves and as he returns to the land of Canaan, echoing the spiritual guardians at the entrance to the garden of Eden.
- Hyperlinks to the flood narrative portray Yaaqov as building his own ark to protect him from the flood of his brother's anger.
- Repeated vocabulary can connect to a distant story, like the flood in this case, or it can set us up for what's coming next.

Yaaqov's Return from Exile



Genesis 32:1-37:1. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

In this final section of the Yaaqov story, he returns to the land to face his brother Esau. He reconciled with Lavan, which gives us hope he can do the same with Esau. But can he be certain? Once again, Yaaqov is thrust into circumstances that will test his trust in Yahweh, who, despite Yaaqov's consistent scheming, has remained committed to his deceitful chosen one. This section of the Yaaqov story is organized into three larger literary units ([Gen. 32:1-33:17](#), [33:18-34:31](#), [35:1-37:1](#)), and each of these has three sub-units (and each of those is made up of three sub-units). The important larger-scale relationships between these three parts illuminate some obscure elements in each.

The Esau/Yaaqov conflict forms the outer frame around the three larger literary units. [Genesis 32:1-11](#) and [Genesis 33:1-17](#) frame the first sub-unit. [Genesis 32:1-11](#) and [Genesis 36:1-37:1](#) frame the entire section.

The smaller stories of Yaaqov having vivid encounters with Yahweh at Peniel ([Gen. 32:23-33](#)) and then at Bethel ([Gen. 35:1-15](#)) form an important inclusion around the center unit, and they also link back to the first Bethel vision ([Gen. 28:10-22](#)) and to Yaaqov's birth narrative where he receives his first name ([Gen. 25:19-34](#)).

In the center of this large section is a contrast unit. While Yaaqov makes peace with Esau and receives his new identity as "Israel" in the outer sections, Yaaqov's sons do just the opposite with the Canaanites. In the center section ([Gen. 33:18-34:31](#)), the sons of Yaaqov are horrified when a Canaanite rapes their sister Dinah. But

instead of seeking justice, they get revenge, and use the covenant sign of circumcision as a ruse to murder the men of an entire town. The sons are not only repeating the sins of their father, they are escalating them to the next level.

This is a sobering section. Yaaqov's return is a kind of celebration, but a muted one at best. His reconciliation with Esau seems only half-hearted, and Yaaqov walks away from the whole affair wounded by God. His sons intensify his past sins, spreading violence in the land, and Yaaqov loses both his favored wife and his father. Yaaqov's sins have caught up with him again, leaving him bereaved and endangered in the land of Canaan. This is all a set-up for the final literary movement of Genesis (Genesis 37-50), where the sins of the fathers come to a head in the ultimate story of sibling rivalry and exile.

Yaaqov and Esau Unite

Genesis 32:2-22

Yaaqov Encounters “Messengers of *Elohim*” at Border Crossing

- **32:2** “This is the camp of Elohim”; “He named the place ‘Two-Camps’ (Heb. *makhanayim* / מחנים)”
- **32:13, 18** Yaaqov sends his flocks ahead as an “offering” (Heb. *minkhah* / מנחה)
- **32:19-21** Yaaqov divides up his flocks and families into 3 groups, himself at the back

Genesis 32:23-33

Yaaqov’s Encounter With the Divine-Human at the Jabbok

- **32:30** “I have seen Elohim face to face!”

Genesis 33:1-17

Yaaqov Encounters Esau

- **33:1-3** Yaaqov sends his families ahead in 3 groups, with himself at the front
- **33:10** “I see your face, as one sees the face of Elohim!”
- **33:10** Yaaqov urges Esau to receive his flocks as an “offering” (Heb. *minkhah* / מנחה)

Genesis 32:2-33:17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

This first part focuses on the reunion of Yaaqov and Esau, and the story unfolds in three units.

- Unit 1 (Gen. 32:2-22): Yaaqov encounters the divine presence as he enters the land, and then he sends for Esau and prepares his entire camp for the meeting. Even though his experience meeting divine messengers tells him that God is present, Yaaqov arranges an elaborate self-protective “offering” by sending his family ahead and staying at the very back. This entire scene shows Yaaqov back at his old ways, making his own scheme to secure his own safety.
- Unit 2 (Gen. 32:23-33): God’s response to Yaaqov’s newest scheme is, in essence, to say “enough is enough.” God shows up personally to pick a fight with Yaaqov, to wound him and give him a new name,

“Struggles With God.” But Yaaqov, tenacious as ever, proves to be a skilled wrestler, and he manages to wrestle a blessing out of the man, even though he walks away permanently wounded.

- Unit 3 (Gen. 33:1-17): The nighttime wrestling match changes Yaaqov, as he now makes himself vulnerable to Esau by going in front of his family. He recognizes that meeting Esau is like meeting Yahweh because it forces him to face his failures. Esau, it turns out, is more generous and forgiving than Yaaqov deserves or could have anticipated. And this becomes an image for Yaaqov's wrestling match with divine and human antagonists.

A crucial motif in this section is the wordplay connection between the Hebrew words “camp” and “offering.”

- Camp = Hebrew מחנה / *makhaneh*
- Offering = Hebrew מנחה / *minkhah*

Yaaqov's visit to “Two-Camps” has a double meaning.

1. “Two camps” is a symbol of God's promise to be with him because the divine and human camps overlap.
2. “Two camps” becomes a symbol of Yaaqov's lack of trust because he divides up his camp into many as a self-protective strategy to hedge against Esau's potential violence.

Yaaqov takes his two camps and divides them into many parts to send ahead as an “offering” to make up for his past wrongs against Esau.

Yaaqov's *minkhah* is made up of his divided *makhaneh* and is an expression of his lack of trust that God is really with him in his *makhanot*!

Genesis 32:1-22 — Yaaqov Sends for Esau

Genesis 32:1-8

Yaaqov Meets Elohim, Sends Messenger To Meet Esau

A - **32:1-2** Yaaqov meets **divine messengers** : “Two-Camps”

B - **32:3-6** Yaaqov sends his **messengers to Esau** ; messengers return, Esau coming with 400 men!

A' - **32:7-8** Yaaqov afraid and divides his people into **two camps**

Genesis 32:9-12

Yaaqov's Prayer for Protection

A - **32:9** Elohim who said **“I will do good to you”**

B - **32:10-11** You have made me into **two camps** ; deliver me!

A' - **32:12** Elohim, you said, **“I will do good to you”**

Genesis 32:13-22

Yaaqov's Scheme To Protect Himself

A - **32:13-16** Yaaqov arranges the animal **offering** for Esau

B - **32:17-18** Yaaqov arranges the three-part camp + the message
A' - **32:19-21** Yaaqov plans to appease Esau with his **offering**

Genesis 32:1-22. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

31:55 And Lavan went and returned to his place.

32:1 And Yaaqov, he went on his way,
and the **messengers** of **Elohim** encountered him,

² and Yaaqov said when he saw them,

“This is the **camp** of **Elohim**!”

And he called the name of that place **Makhanayim [= “Two-Camps”]**.

³ And Yaaqov sent **messengers** **before his face**

to his brother Esau

in the land of **Seir**,

the field of **Edom**.

⁴ **And he commanded them saying,**

“Thus you shall say to my lord Esau:

‘Thus says your servant Yaaqov,

“I was a migrant with Lavan,

and stayed until now;

⁵ I have **oxen and donkeys, flocks and male and female servants;**

and I have sent to tell my lord,

that I may find favor in your sight.””

⁶ And the **messengers** returned to Yaaqov, saying,

“We came to **your brother Esau**,

and also he is coming to meet you,

and four hundred men are with him!”

⁷ And **Yaaqov was afraid, very much,**

and he was distressed;

and he divided the people who were with him,

and the flocks and the herds and the camels,

into **two camps**;

⁸ and he said,

“**If Esau comes** to the one **camp** **and strikes it,**

then the **camp** which remains will escape.”

Genesis 32:1-8. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

⁹ And Yaaqov said,

“ **Elohim** of my father Abraham,

and **Elohim** of my father Isaac,

Yahweh who said to me,

‘Return to your land and to your birth-family,

and I will do good to you,’

¹⁰ I am too small for all of the loyal love and faithfulness

that you have done to your servant,

for with my staff I crossed this Jordan,

and now I have become **two camps** .

¹¹ Deliver me, please,

from the hand of **my brother**,

from the hand of **Esau**;

for **I am afraid of him**,

lest he come and strike me, the mothers with the children.

¹² **For you said**,

‘I will surely do good to you

and I will make your seed as the sand of the sea,

which cannot be counted because of its greatness.’”

Genesis 32:9-12. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Yaaqov's Encounter with Divine Messengers

The apparently random story of Yaaqov's camp and *Elohim*'s camp is located here at Yaaqov's transition between exile and return. When Yaaqov left the land, he encountered the divine presence, by himself, at Bethel (Gen. 28:10-22). And now, as he returns back to the land, he encounters Yahweh again, this time in the form of divine messengers.

Genesis 28:10-22

- Yaaqov meets “divine messengers” (מלאכי אלהים) at the border of the land
- “And he said, ‘This is the house of El!’”
- “And he called the name of the place, ‘House of El.’”

Genesis 29-31

- Yaaqov’s exile in Lavan’s house

Genesis 32:2-3

- Yaaqov meets “divine messengers” (מלאכי אלהים) at the border of the land
- “And he said, ‘This is the camp of Elohim’”
- “And he called the name of the place ‘Two-Camps’”

Genesis 28:10-32:3. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jacob (2021).

Yaaqov's Prayer of Faith or Lack Thereof?

The story of God’s presence with Yaaqov is a tangible expression of God’s promise to be “with” Yaaqov.

Understandably, Yaaqov is afraid. Esau is coming with 400 men! And so we hear what seems to be a heartfelt prayer of panic and distress. Yaaqov acknowledges God’s promise to Yaaqov to have many descendants (although it was to Abraham that God worded the promise this way, not to Yaaqov; see [Gen. 22:17](#)).

Yaaqov attributes his wealth and possessions to Yahweh’s “loyal love and faithfulness.” This important word pair will become a standard expression in describing Yahweh’s character in [Exodus 34:6-7](#). But the phrase has appeared one time before this, in an important parallel story about Abraham’s servant who was on his way to Lavan’s house to look for a wife for Yitskhaq.

Genesis 24:27 Instructor’s Translation

He said, “Blessed be Yahweh, **the Elohim of my master Abraham**, who has not forsaken **his loyal love and faithfulness** toward my master; as for me, Yahweh has guided me in the way to the house of my master’s brothers.”

Genesis 32:9-10 Instructor’s Translation

⁹ Yaaqov said, **“O Elohim of my father Abraham and Elohim of my father Yitskhaq ...** ¹⁰ I am unworthy of all **the loyal love and faithfulness** which you have shown to your servant; for with my staff only I crossed this Jordan, and now I have become two companies.”

In both stories, a member of Abraham’s house is traveling the same road between Canaan and Kharan. And in both stories, the future of the family of Abraham is at stake. In both cases, it is only Yahweh’s loyal love that will keep the chosen seed alive.

13 **So he spent the night there .**

And he took from what came into his hand as an **offering** to **Esau his brother**:

14 two hundred female goats¹
and twenty male goats,²

two hundred ewe-lambs,³
and twenty rams,⁴

15 thirty nursing camels⁵
and their colts,⁶

forty cows⁷
and ten bulls,⁸

twenty female donkeys⁹
and ten male donkeys.¹⁰

16 **And he gave** into the hand of his servants
each herd by itself,

and said to his servants,

"Pass on before my face,
and put a **resting** space between herds."

17 **And he commanded the first , saying,**

"When **my brother Esau** encounters you and asks you, saying,
'To whom do you belong,
and where are you going,
and to whom do these **before your face** belong?'

18 **and you shall say,**

'They belong to your servant, to Yaaqov;
it is an **offering** sent to my lord, to **Esau**.
And behold, he also is behind us.'"

19 **And he commanded also the second ,**

and also the third ,

and also all those who followed the herds, **saying,**

"According to this word you shall speak to **Esau** when you find him,

20 **and you will say,**

'Behold, your servant Yaaqov also is behind us.'"

For he said,

"I will cover-over **his face** with the **offering** that goes **before my face**
and afterward **I will see his face** ;
perhaps **he will lift up my face** ."

21 And the **offering** passed on **before his face** ,
and he himself spent that night in the **camp** .

Yaaqov's Peace Offering or Self-Protective Scheme?

The story about Yaaqov preparing an offering for Esau could be taken a couple ways.

1. It could be that he is genuinely sorry and offers a huge gift to make up for his huge deception 20 years ago. The long ten-fold list of animals describes an enormous amount of wealth.
2. It could be an elaborate self-protective scheme meant to pacify his brother's anger and butter him up before seeing Yaaqov face to face. Recall that Yaaqov's fear, expressed back in [Genesis 32:9-12](#) is that "Esau may come ... and strike the camp!" Yaaqov puts his entire camp ahead of himself, placing his wives, children, slaves, and animals in harm's way. While he does say the purpose of the offering is to "cover-over" his face, that is, appease his anger with a valuable gift, it's curious that Yaaqov puts himself far behind instead of out front. The fact that Yaaqov places himself behind the camp is twice emphasized, which draws our attention to this detail.

"The Greater One Will Serve the Smaller One"

The birth oracle intimated that the "greater" would serve the "younger" ([Gen. 25:23](#)). But the story that follows shows the exact opposite coming to pass.

The younger Yaaqov (at the instigation of his mother) schemes a way to get his own blessing instead of waiting for God to grant it in due time. And he pays dearly for these deceptions. Esau's anger exiles Yaaqov to Lavan's house, where he is deceived in return and becomes a "servant" to Lavan (contrary to the birth oracle). He leaves Lavan's house when he "sees his face" has changed (see [Gen. 31:2, 5](#)) and then he flees (just as he fled from Esau).

When Yaaqov returns, he schemes his way back into Esau's favor only to bow to him and declare that he is Esau's servant (see [Gen. 32:19](#)). He says that seeing Esau's face is like seeing the face of God, which is more merciful to him in his humiliation and helplessness than he anticipated.

Genesis 25:23 NASB

The LORD said to her, "Two nations are in your womb; and two peoples will be separated from your body; and one people shall be stronger than the other; and **the greater** shall **serve** the younger."

Genesis 29:18-20 NASB

¹⁸ Now Jacob loved Rachel, so he said, "I will **serve** you seven years for your younger daughter Rachel." ...
²⁰ So Jacob **served** seven years for Rachel and they seemed to him but a few days because of his love for her.

Genesis 32:4 NASB

He also commanded them saying, "Thus you shall say to **my master Esau** : 'Thus says **your servant** Jacob, "I have sojourned with Laban, and stayed until now;'"

Ironically, both of these “greater ones” (Esau and Lavan) end up having the “younger” Yaaqov as their servant, and he sees both of their faces, one unfavorable and the other gracious, as though seeing the face of God.

In a strange paradox, it is precisely by becoming a suffering servant to the nations (Esau the father of Edom, Lavan the Aramean) that Yaaqov finally becomes a vehicle of God’s peace and blessing to both of them.

And this idea, the suffering of Yaaqov the servant of God that brings blessing to others, this is what the following strange story is all about.

Reflection Question

How do you interpret Yaaqov’s actions as he prepares to meet his brother?